



BRIAN VANDER BRUG Los Angeles Times

MEXICAN national guard troops help with the grim task of searching for human remains in the rubble of a beachfront home in Malibu.

No power cut was warranted, utility says

Winds weren't strong enough to require a shutdown before Eaton fire, Edison chief executive says.

BY NOAH GOLDBERG

The head of Southern California Edison said Wednesday that winds blowing in Eaton Canyon on Jan. 7 were not strong enough to merit de-energizing a powerful transmission electrical line that is now being investigated as a possible ignition point for a fire that devastated a large swath of Altadena.

Residents who live near Eaton Canyon reported seeing flames erupt at the bottom of the tower as the fire got underway and took photos and videos of the scene. Over the weekend, Cal Fire investigators were at the tower and said the area was off limits because it was part of the investigation into what sparked the Eaton fire.

Chief Executive Steven Powell, a 25-year veteran of the company, reiterated in an interview with The Times the company's assertion that its data showed no abnormalities in the 12 hours leading up to the ignition of the Eaton fire. He added that the towers in the area were built in the 1970s and 1980s and that both the lines and towers had most recently been inspected in 2024.

"We do an aerial inspection that's either helicopter or most often we're using drones, because you can get up close and get great images of every little piece, and then our inspectors are going on the ground with binoculars and looking at them," Powell said.

The National Weather Service had warned of life-threatening and destructive winds for the day fires broke out in Pacific Palisades and Altadena.

Powell said Edison was monitoring the weather closely Jan. 7 but said the winds did not meet the threshold the company uses for de-energizing transmission.

Displaced residents' frustration mounts as wait to return drags on

BY ANDREA CHANG, HANNAH FRY, RICHARD WINTON, NATHAN SOLIS AND RONG-GONG LIN II

As winds began to die down Wednesday, there was growing despair and frustration in the vast fire zones among residents who were demanding to get back into their neighborhoods.

A brigade of firefighters spent the day reinforcing containment lines and cooling hot spots in the Palisades and Eaton fires to lessen the risk that strong winds would carry embers into unburned areas. Officials estimate that the fires have destroyed more than 12,000 structures, including many homes, making them two of the most destructive — and deadliest — wildfires in California history.

[See Residents, A6]



ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

FIRE VICTIMS seek aid at a FEMA relief site Tuesday in Pasadena. Crews have largely stopped growth of the Palisades and Eaton fires.



ABDEL KAREEM HANA Associated Press

PALESTINIANS in Deir al Balah, Gaza Strip, celebrate the news of a cease-fire agreement between Israel and Hamas, which promises to end the 15-month war and free some Israeli hostages and Palestinian prisoners.

CEASE-FIRE DEAL IS REACHED

BY TRACY WILKINSON, LAURA KING AND NABIH BULOS

WASHINGTON — More than 15 months into Israel's devastating war with Hamas militants in the Gaza Strip, the two sides have agreed to a cease-fire deal that would pause fighting and free some Israeli hostages in exchange for the release of Palestinian prisoners, U.S. and Qatari officials said Wednesday.

"At long last, I can announce a cease-fire, and a hostage deal, has been reached between Israel and Hamas," President Biden said from the White House.

The guidelines of the hard-fought agreement were first presented by Biden in the spring, but months of negotiations repeatedly failed to bring the two enemies together.

The cease-fire, which begins Sunday, starts with a six-week period during which fighting stops and hostages are released. During that period negotiations for a permanent end to the war will commence, Biden said.

"After 15 months of terror ... hostages will go home," the president said. "And the Palestinian people have gone through hell. Too many people have died."

Qatar's prime minister, Sheikh Mohammed bin Abdulrahman al Thani, first announced the deal at a news conference in the Qatari capital, Doha. "We hope this will be the last page in these times of war," he said. "We tell our brothers in Gaza, we will always support the Palestinian people."

U.S., Qatari and Egyptian negotiators spent months holding extensive

LAFD tactics come under scrutiny

Top agency officials defend decisions on staffing and engines made in advance of the Palisades fire.

BY PAUL PRINGLE, ALENE TCHEKMEDYIAN AND DAKOTA SMITH

As the Los Angeles Fire Department faced extraordinary warnings of life-threatening winds, top commanders decided not to assign for emergency deployment roughly 1,000 available firefighters and dozens of water-carrying engines in advance of the fire that destroyed much of Pacific Palisades and continues to burn, interviews and internal LAFD records show.

Fire officials chose not to order the firefighters to remain on duty for a second shift on Jan. 7 as the winds were building — which would have doubled the personnel on hand — and staffed just five of more than 40 engines that are available to aid in battling wildfires, according to the records obtained by The Times, as well as interviews with LAFD officials and former chiefs with knowledge of city operations.

The department started calling up more firefighters and deploying those additional engines only after the Palisades blaze was burning out of control.

No extra engines had been placed in the Palisades, where the fire broke out about 10:30 a.m. on Jan. 7, officials said. The department pre-positioned nine engines to the San Fernando Valley

[See Tactics, A5]

Suspected rent gouging rises, as does the backlash

Listings show jumps despite new rules. Tenant advocates and even landlord groups call them out.

BY LIAM DILLON, JACK FLEMMING, ANDREW KHOURI AND SEEMA MEHTA

In the Beverly Grove neighborhood of Los Angeles, the asking rent for a two-bedroom condo jumped from \$5,000 to \$8,000 in the wake of the fires that started last week and have left thousands homeless.

In Venice, a single-family house saw a jump of nearly 60%. In Santa Monica, an owner listed a five-bedroom house for \$15,000 above what they were asking last year — a gain of more than 100%.

Temporary price-gouging protections in place because of the fires are supposed to stop such dramatic rent hikes, but a Times review of online listings this week indicate illegal increases are relatively common. Such listings, which have been denounced on social media, are starting an uproar, causing some landlords to shift course and

[See Rents, A7]

MORE FIRE COVERAGE INSIDE

The top claim deniers

Farmers affiliates lead a ratings agency's list of California home insurance firms that rejected filings in 2023. **BUSINESS, A8**

Evacuees find solace

A group of displaced homeowners, no longer strangers, bonds over breakfast each day at a hotel. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Strain from Olympics?

The L.A. area will host three major sports events, including the 2028 Summer Games, while rebuilding is ongoing. **SPORTS, B10**

A loss for L.A. music

The Palisades and Eaton fires devastated two neighborhoods that held unique significance in the industry. **ENTERTAINMENT, E1**

Weather

Mostly sunny; breezy. L.A. Basin: 67/45. **B6**

